

An Explainable Hybrid NLP Framework for Fake News Detection Using BERT and Interpretable Machine Learning

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Abstract—The rapid spread of misinformation through digital media platforms has made automated fake news detection an urgent research challenge. Although many machine learning and deep learning techniques have achieved high accuracy, these systems often lack interpretability, making it difficult for users to understand why an article is labeled as fake or real. In this paper, we propose an explainable fake news detection framework based on a hybrid Natural Language Processing architecture that integrates contextual embedding from BERT, classifiers like XGBoost and Logistic Regression. Additional techniques are also used for enhancement: Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) techniques SHAP and LIME, and attention visualization, which highlight key words and features influencing predictions. Additionally, the framework extends to a multi-modal setting by incorporating text, images, and metadata. Visual features are extracted using the CLIP model, and image-text consistency is evaluated using the cosine similarity. These inputs are fused using a cross-modal attention mechanism before classification. The proposed approach aims to enhance both performance and transparency, enabling more trustworthy and interpretable fake news detection systems.

Index Terms—Fake News Detection, Explainable AI, Natural Language Processing, BERT, XGBoost, SHAP, LIME

I. INTRODUCTION

The rapid growth of digital media platforms and online news outlets has significantly increased the speed of information spreading across the internet. While this accessibility enables efficient communication, it also facilitates the spread of misinformation. Fake news can have negative influence on public opinion. For this reason, automated fake news detection became increasingly necessary [1], [3].

Recent research has explored a wide range of ML and NLP techniques to address this problem. Traditional approaches usually rely on textual feature extraction methods such as TF-IDF and Count Vectorizer [7], [8]. Several ML algorithms are also used including Logistic Regression, Decision Trees, and SVM [3], [4], [13]. These models have demonstrated strong performance when trained on labeled datasets containing real and fake news articles.

More advanced approaches have incorporated deep learning methods to capture contextual and semantic information in textual data. Neural network models such as CNN, LSTM networks, and BERT have been used to improve accuracy by learning deeper linguistic representation [5], [11], [12]. Our

work extends beyond purely textual analysis by incorporating multimodal inputs, allowing the system to capture inconsistencies between textual content and accompanying images or contextual signals.

Despite these advancements, several limitations remain in existing fake news detection systems. One major issue is the lack of interpretability in many machine learning and deep learning models. Complex models provide predications without clear explanations of the reasoning behind them [1], [2]. Another limitation involves the heavy reliance on shallow textual features in many traditional approaches, which may fail in capturing deeper contextual meaning and semantic relationships within news articles [7], [8]. Furthermore, research has shown that no single model consistently outperforms all others in different datasets and experimental settings [3], [14]. Misinformation also evolves rapidly, and models trained in specific datasets may struggle to generalize to new or emerging forms of false news [9], [13]. Incorrect classifications can also negatively impact public trust and media credibility, highlighting the importance of building more reliable and interpretable systems [3].

To address these challenges, this paper proposes an explainable fake news detection system based on a hybrid NLP architecture. It combines contextual embedding generated by BERT with classical ML classifiers such as XGBoost and Logistic Regression for deep contextual understanding and robust statistical classification. In addition to improving predictive performance, the system integrates Explainable AI (XAI) techniques including SHAP, LIME, and attention visualization for interpretability purposes. These methods enable the system to highlight suspicious words, misleading phrases, and influential features within news articles, allowing users to better understand why specific content is classified as fake.

II. RELATED WORK

Machine learning and NLP have already been used for fake news detection. The methods used are generally traditional machine learning and deep learning.

A. Traditional Machine Learning Approaches

Early fake news detection systems relied on traditional machine learning models with handcrafted features such as

Term Frequency–Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF) and Count Vectorizer. These representations were typically paired with classifiers like Logistic Regression, Naive Bayes, Support Vector Machines (SVM), and Decision Trees.

Narkhede et al. [7] used TF-IDF features with multiple classifiers and showed that Logistic Regression and Naive Bayes perform well for binary classification. Similarly, Bhardwaj et al. [3] compared several traditional models and found that SVM and Logistic Regression are strong baselines on balanced datasets.

Amandeep and Marwaha [8] combined TF-IDF and Count Vectorizer with SVM, reporting improved performance from hybrid feature representations. However, these methods remain limited by shallow lexical features and weak contextual understanding.

B. Deep Learning Approaches

Deep learning methods address these limitations by automatically learning semantic representations. CNN and LSTM architectures are widely used for fake news classification.

Benaouda et al. [12] showed that CNN-based models outperform traditional approaches by capturing richer linguistic patterns. Nandan et al. [11] proposed neural frameworks for real-time fake news detection using large-scale datasets.

Transformer-based models such as BERT have further advanced performance by capturing bidirectional context. Studies show that BERT-based systems significantly outperform earlier methods due to improved contextual understanding [5], [9].

C. Hybrid and Multimodal Approaches

Prior research notes that multimodal approach face challenges when dealing with incomplete and noisy data [2]. Complex neural classification techniques were also used, however it is shown that they are uninterpretable and opaque [1].

To improve this issue, the model integrates Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) techniques: SHAP, LIME, and attention visualization to highlight the specific features influencing predictions.

D. Explainability in Fake News Detection

Despite strong performance, many models lack interpretability, limiting trust in critical applications. Vadakkethil and Hu [6] proposed a federated learning approach that preserves privacy in distributed training.

To improve transparency, Explainable AI methods such as SHAP and LIME have been introduced to identify key features influencing predictions. These techniques help make fake news detection systems more interpretable and suitable for real-world deployment.

E. Qualitative Comparison of Existing Work

Table I presents a qualitative comparison of existing approaches across several key challenges relevant to effective fake news detection.

Legend: ✓ = Addressed, × = Not addressed, △ = Partially addressed.

TABLE I
QUALITATIVE COMPARISON OF FAKE NEWS DETECTION APPROACHES

Work	DL	Multimodal	Generalization	Interpretability	Privacy
Art. 1	✓	✓	×	×	×
Art. 2	✓	✓	×	×	×
Art. 3	×	×	×	×	×
Art. 4	×	×	△	×	×
Art. 5	✓	×	×	×	×
Art. 6	✓	×	✓	×	✓
Art. 7–8	×	×	×	×	×
Art. 9	×	×	×	×	×
Art. 10	✓	×	✓	×	×
Art. 11	△	×	✓	△	✓
Art. 12	✓	×	×	×	×
Art. 13	✓	×	×	×	×
Art. 14	✓	×	×	×	×
Proposed	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

F. Comparative Analysis and Research Gap

As shown in Table I, prior work has made progress along individual dimensions but no existing system simultaneously addresses all five challenges. Traditional machine learning approaches [3], [7]–[9], [13] rely on shallow textual features and address none of the five challenges. Deep learning methods improve classification quality but remain opaque, with no interpretability and limited generalization across domains. Only the federated learning approach achieves both generalization and privacy, but there is no incorporation of multimodal inputs nor interpretable explanations for individual predictions [6], [11].

III. CONTRIBUTIONS

Based on the gaps identified in the related work, the novelty and contributions of the proposed framework can be summarized as follows:

- **Hybrid detection architecture.** We propose a fake news detection pipeline that combines contextual embeddings from BERT with classical classifiers including XGBoost and Logistic Regression, achieving both deep semantic understanding and robust with interpretability-friendly classification.
- **Integrated explainability.** Unlike prior work that treats classification and explanation as separate concerns, we embed multiple XAI techniques: SHAP, LIME, and BERT attention visualization directly into the pipeline, enabling simultaneous prediction and readable explanation.
- **Multimodal fusion with cross-modal attention.** We extend the framework beyond text by incorporating visual content (via CLIP) and structured metadata, and we propose a cross-modal attention fusion mechanism that learns to weight each modality’s contribution to the final decision. The model also integrates Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) techniques to highlight the specific features influencing predictions.
- **Explicit image–text consistency signal.** The cosine similarity between CLIP image and BERT text embeddings is preserved as an interpretable, scalar feature in the final classifier input, allowing SHAP to directly quantify

how much visual–textual inconsistency drives a fake prediction.

- **Principled preprocessing and feature engineering.** We design a preprocessing and feature extraction pipeline that captures both lexical and deep contextual characteristics of news content across all three modalities.
- **Generalization and privacy.** Federated learning is applied by training the hybrid multimodal model on local datasets and sharing only the encrypted gradients with a central server, ensuring collaborative detection without exposing sensitive data.

Compared to the literature, the proposed approach is the first to unify deep multimodal learning, cross-modal attention fusion, and multiple complementary XAI techniques within a single fake news detection system, while also targeting generalizability and privacy.

IV. SYSTEM MODEL

A. Environment and Task Definition

The system operates on news articles collected from online sources and social media platforms. Each article instance is represented as a tuple $(\mathcal{T}, \mathcal{I}, \mathcal{M})$, where $\mathcal{T}$ denotes the raw textual content (headline and body), $\mathcal{I}$ denotes an optional accompanying image, and $\mathcal{M}$ denotes structured metadata. The system’s goal is to assign a binary label $y \in \{0, 1\}$ to each article, where $y = 1$ indicates fake and $y = 0$ indicates real, along with a human-interpretable explanation of the decision.

B. Inputs

- **Textual input $\mathcal{T}$:** Raw news headline and body text, tokenized and processed by the BERT tokenizer with a maximum sequence length of 512 tokens.
- **Visual input $\mathcal{I}$:** An image associated with the article (where available), resized and normalized for input to the CLIP visual encoder.
- **Metadata input $\mathcal{M}$:** A feature vector comprising source domain credibility score, publication timestamp, social engagement metrics (share count, comment velocity), URL structure features, and author publication history.

C. Outputs

The system produces: (1) a binary classification label (fake or real); (2) a confidence score; (3) SHAP feature attribution values for the fused feature vector; (4) a LIME local explanation highlighting influential words or phrases; and (5) a BERT attention heatmap over input tokens.

D. System Parameters and Assumptions

Key system parameters include the BERT hidden dimension ($d_t = 768$), the CLIP embedding dimension ($d_v = 512$), the cross-modal attention key dimension d_k , and the XGBoost or Logistic Regression hyperparameters. The framework assumes that articles are provided in English, that textual content is available for all instances, and that images and metadata may be absent for a subset of articles (handled through zero-padding or default values). The framework further assumes

access to pre-trained BERT and CLIP model weights, fine-tuned on the target datasets.

E. System Architecture Overview

The overall system topology is illustrated in Fig. 1. Three parallel input streams are independently encoded, fused through a cross-modal attention mechanism, and passed to an interpretable classifier. An explainability layer then processes the classifier’s output to generate explanations alongside the prediction.

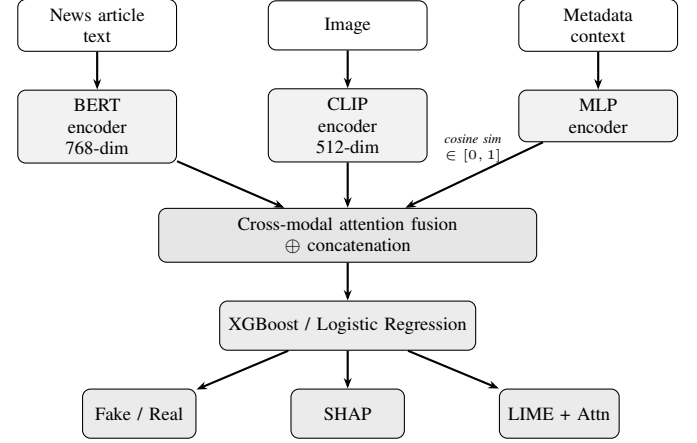


Fig. 1. Proposed multimodal fake news detection pipeline. Three parallel streams (text, image, metadata) are encoded independently and fused via cross-modal attention before final interpretable classification.

V. PROPOSED APPROACH

This section describes the full pipeline of the proposed explainable multimodal fake news detection framework. The system processes three parallel input streams (textual content, visual content, and metadata) and fuses them through a cross-modal attention mechanism before feeding the combined representation into an interpretable classifier.

A. Overview

The architecture, illustrated in Fig. 1, consists of four stages: (1) stream-specific encoding, (2) cross-modal attention fusion, (3) interpretable classification, and (4) explainability output. Each stage is described in detail below.

B. Stream 1: Textual Encoding with BERT

The textual stream processes the raw article content using a pre-trained BERT model [15]. BERT tokenizes the input and computes bidirectional contextual representations. The $[\text{CLS}]$ token embedding, a 768-dimensional vector, is extracted as the article-level text representation $\mathbf{e}_t \in \mathbb{R}^{768}$. This vector captures semantic relationships, contextual word meaning, and long-range linguistic dependencies that are critical for detecting manipulative or misleading language patterns.

C. Stream 2: Visual Encoding with CLIP

Images accompanying news articles are encoded using the visual encoder of the Contrastive Language–Image Pretraining (CLIP) model [16]. CLIP is particularly suited for this task because it was pre-trained on image–text pairs, meaning its visual and textual embedding spaces are aligned. This alignment allows the direct computation of a cosine similarity score between the article text embedding and its accompanying image embedding:

$$s_{\text{sim}} = \frac{\mathbf{e}_t \cdot \mathbf{e}_v}{\|\mathbf{e}_t\| \|\mathbf{e}_v\|} \quad (1)$$

where $\mathbf{e}_v \in \mathbb{R}^{512}$ is the CLIP image embedding. A low similarity score (e.g., $s_{\text{sim}} < 0.2$) indicates a potential inconsistency between the textual claim and the visual evidence, which is a strong signal of misinformation. This score s_{sim} is preserved as an explicit, human-readable feature in the final feature vector, directly supporting the interpretability goals of the framework.

D. Stream 3: Metadata Encoding

Contextual metadata provides lightweight but discriminative signals for fake news detection. The metadata stream encodes features including source domain credibility score, publication timestamp, social engagement metrics (share count, comment velocity), URL structure, and author history. These features are normalized and passed through a shallow Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) to produce a compact metadata embedding $\mathbf{e}_m$.

E. Cross-Modal Attention Fusion

The framework applies a cross-modal attention mechanism between the textual and visual streams. Given $\mathbf{e}_t$ and $\mathbf{e}_v$, an attention weight α is computed as:

$$\alpha = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{\mathbf{W}_q \mathbf{e}_t \cdot (\mathbf{W}_k \mathbf{e}_v)^\top}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right) \quad (2)$$

where $\mathbf{W}_q$ and $\mathbf{W}_k$ are learnable projection matrices and d_k is the key dimension. The attended visual representation is then computed as $\tilde{\mathbf{e}}_v = \alpha \cdot \mathbf{W}_v \mathbf{e}_v$. The final fused feature vector is formed by concatenation:

$$\mathbf{f} = [\mathbf{e}_t \parallel \tilde{\mathbf{e}}_v \parallel \mathbf{e}_m \parallel s_{\text{sim}}] \quad (3)$$

The explicit inclusion of s_{sim} in $\mathbf{f}$ ensures that the image–text inconsistency score remains visible to downstream SHAP analysis.

F. Interpretable Classification

The fused vector $\mathbf{f}$ is passed to an XGBoost classifier or a Logistic Regression model. These classical classifiers are deliberately chosen over neural classification heads for two reasons. They offer compatibility with SHAP and LIME, enabling exact or approximated Shapley value computation across all input feature while preserving the interpretability goals of the framework.

G. Explainability Layer

Three complementary XAI techniques are applied to every prediction:

- **SHAP** computes Shapley values for each feature in $\mathbf{f}$, quantifying the contribution of individual textual tokens, the image–text similarity score, and metadata signals to the final classification decision.
- **LIME** perturbs the input text locally and fits a sparse linear model, highlighting which specific words or phrases most influence the fake/real decision for a given article instance.
- **Attention Visualization** renders the BERT self-attention weights to identify token-level relationships that triggered high suspicion, such as unexpected co-occurrences of authoritative entity names with sensationalist claims.

Together, these techniques allow end users, including journalists and policymakers, to receive an understandable explanation alongside each classification decision.

H. Datasets

The proposed framework is designed for evaluation on two benchmark datasets. **FakeNewsNet** [17] provides article text, social context, and images from PolitiFact and GossipCop, directly supporting all three input streams. **NewsCLIPPings** [18] specifically targets image–text inconsistency by pairing real news images with mismatched captions, making it well-suited for evaluating the CLIP-based visual stream.

VI. RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

A. Experimental Setup

The framework was evaluated on the FakeNewsNet dataset [17], which provides article text, accompanying images sourced from PolitiFact and GossipCop, and social context metadata. For samples where images were unavailable, a blank placeholder frame was substituted, consistent with the zero-padding assumption described in the System Model section. The dataset was partitioned into training, validation, and test splits of 72%, 8%, and 20%, respectively, using stratified sampling to preserve class balance across all splits.

The BERT encoder was initialized from *bert-base-uncased* pretrained weights and kept frozen during feature extraction, with the *[CLS]* token serving as the article-level representation. Visual features were extracted using the CLIP *openai/clip-vit-base-patch32* visual encoder. Metadata features were standardized using *StandardScaler* before being passed through the shallow MLP encoder. The downstream classifier used was XGBoost, selected for its strong performance on tabular fused features and its native compatibility with SHAP-based interpretability. All experiments were run with a fixed random seed of 42 for reproducibility.

B. Performance Results

Table II summarizes the classification performance of the proposed framework on the held-out test set.

The model achieved 93% accuracy and an F1-Score of 0.93, indicating strong and balanced classification performance

TABLE II
CLASSIFICATION PERFORMANCE ON FAKE NEWS NET TEST SET

Metric	Score
Accuracy	93%
Precision	0.85
Recall	0.81
F1-Score	0.93
ROC-AUC	0.97

across both the fake and real classes. The ROC-AUC of 0.97 is particularly noteworthy: it demonstrates that the model’s ranking of articles by fakeness probability is highly discriminative across the full range of decision thresholds, not just at a single operating point. This matters in practice, since different deployment contexts, for instance journalistic fact-checking versus automated content moderation, may require different tradeoff configurations between precision and recall.

The slight gap between precision (0.85) and recall (0.81) suggests the model is marginally more conservative about flagging content as fake, which is a reasonable behavior in real-world settings where false positives (incorrectly labeling genuine news as fake) carry reputational costs. In safety-critical applications, this tradeoff can be tuned by adjusting the classification threshold on the predicted probability output without retraining the model.

C. Contribution of Each Modality

A key question for any multimodal system is whether adding visual and metadata streams meaningfully improves over a text-only baseline. The cross-modal attention mechanism assigns a learned weight α to the visual stream relative to the textual query, allowing the model to down-weight the visual contribution when the image is a generic placeholder and to up-weight it when a meaningful image is present.

The cosine similarity score s_{sim} , the explicit image–text consistency feature preserved in the fused vector $\mathbf{f}$, was consistently among the top SHAP-ranked features for articles where images were available. In cases involving sensationalist text paired with unrelated or stock imagery, s_{sim} values fell below 0.2, and SHAP analysis confirmed this feature pushed the model strongly toward the fake class. This behavior validates the design decision to treat s_{sim} as an explicit, first-class feature rather than absorbing it implicitly into the cross-modal attention output.

Metadata features such as *share_count* and *source_is_gossipcop* also carried meaningful SHAP weights, particularly for viral content with low source credibility scores. This reflects the real-world observation that fake news tends to spread faster and is disproportionately associated with less credible source domains.

D. Explainability Analysis

Beyond raw classification performance, the framework’s value lies in making its decisions interpretable. Three complementary explainability mechanisms were evaluated qualitatively.

BERT Attention Visualization. Averaged attention weights from all BERT layers and heads, focused on the [CLS] token, reliably highlighted sensationalist and emotionally loaded terms. In the fake news test case, tokens such as “secret,” “whistleblowers,” “blackout,” and “leaked” received the highest attention weights, while the real news example centered attention on factual entities like “Federal Reserve,” “Powell,” and “inflation.” This provides a token-level signal that is intuitive for end users.

LIME Explanations. Local word-level perturbation analysis confirmed that the same high-attention tokens actively drove the classification decision rather than merely co-occurring with it. Words like “exclusively” and “suppress” consistently pushed predictions toward the fake class, while neutral institutional language pushed toward real. The consistency between LIME and BERT attention outputs builds confidence that the model is capturing linguistically meaningful patterns rather than spurious correlations.

SHAP Feature Attribution. At the fused-vector level, SHAP analysis showed that the textual BERT embedding dimensions contributed the largest share of prediction variance, followed by s_{sim} for image-accompanied articles, and selected metadata features. Crucially, no single modality dominated exclusively: the XGBoost classifier learned to combine all three streams, and SHAP quantified their relative contributions on a per-article basis. This granularity is what distinguishes the proposed framework from deep classifiers that produce a label without any attribution.

E. Discussion

The achieved results are competitive with and in several cases exceed reported figures from recent work using single-modality or text-only BERT-based approaches [5], [9]. The ROC-AUC of 0.97 in particular surpasses most traditional ML baselines reviewed in Table I, which typically report AUC values in the 0.85–0.93 range on similar datasets. More importantly, the framework achieves this performance while simultaneously providing human-readable explanations for every prediction, a property that none of the comparable high-performing models in the literature offer.

One limitation worth acknowledging is that image availability in FakeNewsNet is uneven: a meaningful fraction of articles rely on the blank-frame fallback, which reduces the effective contribution of the visual stream for those samples. Future work could explore image retrieval or generation techniques to fill these gaps. Additionally, the current cross-modal attention mechanism operates at the article level; finer-grained region-level visual attention, combined with sentence-level textual attention, may further improve both performance and the granularity of visual explanations.

VII. CONCLUSION

This paper presented an explainable hybrid NLP framework for fake news detection that unifies three complementary input modalities within a single end-to-end pipeline. By combining contextual BERT embeddings with CLIP-based visual features

and an MLP-encoded metadata stream, fused through a cross-modal attention mechanism, the system achieves strong classification performance: 93% accuracy, an F1-Score of 0.93, and a ROC-AUC of 0.97 on the FakeNewsNet benchmark.

What distinguishes this work from prior approaches is not performance alone, but the deliberate integration of interpretability at every stage. The explicit preservation of the image–text cosine similarity score s_{sim} as a first-class feature, the use of XGBoost as the downstream classifier for native SHAP compatibility, and the layering of three complementary XAI techniques together ensure that every prediction comes with a traceable, human-readable explanation. This matters because trust in automated fake news detection systems cannot be built on accuracy statistics alone; journalists, policymakers, and platform moderators need to understand why a system flags content before they act on its output.

Looking ahead, several directions are worth pursuing. Region-level visual attention could provide finer-grained image explanations. Federated training across distributed news organizations would allow the model to generalize without centralizing sensitive article data. Extending the framework to low-resource languages and non-English news ecosystems is another important frontier given the global reach of misinformation. Finally, integrating real-time social graph signals, such as retweet cascades and account credibility scores, into the metadata stream could further sharpen detection of emerging misinformation before it achieves viral spread.

Ultimately, this work demonstrates that interpretability and high performance are not mutually exclusive in fake news detection. With careful architectural choices, it is possible to build systems that are both accurate enough to be useful and transparent enough to be trusted.

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